





head produce a three-dimensional sense of space that redefines what a soundbar system can do in a living room. The height does not reach the convincing solidity of a dedicated ceiling-mounted speaker: sequences designed to place a single localised sound directly above the listener reveal the limits of an up-firing driver in a typical room. But across the broader soundfield and particularly in the spatial atmosphere that well-mixed Atmos content creates around and above the listener, the Bar 1300 MK2 is consistently more convincing than competing soundbar systems at similar or higher prices.

Dialogue clarity is strong throughout, with or without PureVoice active. The centre channel in the main bar reproduces speech naturally and at the right level relative to the rest of the soundtrack. In dense, sonically complex passages, PureVoice 2.0 provides forward presence for voices without processing artefacts. In quiet scenes, it is not doing anything to the sound, which is exactly the right behaviour.

One honest caveat for Atmos viewers is that with the rear speakers docked on the main bar, the system does not virtualise rear Atmos channels. The full Atmos experience requires the rear speakers to be detached and placed behind the listening position. With rears docked, the system produces a wide and powerful front stage with front height from the bar's up-firing drivers, but no rear channel information at all. For casual daily viewing, this is fine and the front stage alone is impressive. For Dolby Atmos films, detaching the rears is not optional but a necessity to experience the wider soundstage.

MUSIC

The Bar 1300 MK2's musicality is one of its better qualities and Dolby Atmos music is where the system's architecture becomes most apparent. Atmos music, increasingly available on Apple Music and in physical media, uses the overhead and surround channels for spatial elements and ambience rather than directional sound effects. On a system with physical height and surround channels at both front and rear, this translates into a listening experience where instruments and vocals gain spatial separation that does not exist in conventional stereo. Ambient elements in a mix occupy the room rather than the speakers. At adequate volume, the effect is striking for a soundbar system.

Stereo music is equally capable. The mid-range is clear, the treble is articulate without edging into sharpness and the bass, managed via the EQ, supports well-mastered recordings with real weight. At default settings, the bass level is generous for acoustic and vocal content. A modest EQ adjustment addresses this in minutes.

VERDICT

At Rs 1,50,000, the JBL Bar 1300 MK2 is asking for a commitment. What it offers in return is a Dolby Atmos soundbar experience that does not need the format claim, qualified with caveats about virtualisation or simulated height. The 11.1.4 configuration is physically real: 29 drivers, dedicated channels, up-firing height at both ends of the room.

The Bar 1300 MK2 rewards proper setup, the right room and Dolby Atmos content mixed to take advantage of what 11.1.4 channels do. For buyers who have all three, the experience it delivers is the best argument the soundbar category has made for the Dolby Atmos format. It is a system that stops asking you to imagine what Atmos sounds like simply just lets you listen to.

– Siddharth Chauhan

SPECIFICATIONS

Channel count: 11.1.4 | Total drivers: 29 | Maximum power output: 2,470 W | Subwoofer: Wireless, dual 8-inch opposed drivers, 1,200 W, sealed cabinet | Rear speakers: Detachable, battery-powered (10 hours), USB-C charging | HDMI inputs: 3x HDMI 2.0b with 4K/60Hz passthrough | HDMI output: 1x eARC | Wireless: Wi-Fi 6, Bluetooth 5.3 (bar) / 5.4 (rears), AirPlay 2, Chromecast | Streaming: Spotify Connect, Tidal Connect, Roon | Audio formats: Dolby Atmos, DTS:X, Dolby Digital Plus, PCM

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